



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 36

OHIO

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Ohio's family courts and child-welfare system.

100

OHIO FAMILIES ON RECORD · 118
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 24 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
38 OF 88

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

OHIO AT A GLANCE.

Across 100 Ohio families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 118 99 of 100 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$15,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 24 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 50.0% 33.0% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 100	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.2	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 99 of 100	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 38

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Ohio families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF OHIO FAMILY COURT

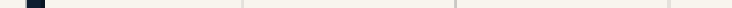
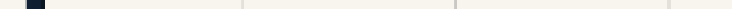
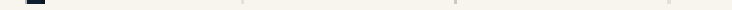
Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

Expense Category	Responses	Median	Mean	Total Reported
Attorney Fees	54	\$15,000	\$76,974	\$4,156,600
Lost Wages	50	\$5,150	\$128,244	\$6,412,190
Other Court Fees	37	\$500	\$4,081	\$151,015
Therapy / Evaluations	42	\$1,000	\$7,537	\$316,560
Reunification Services	45	\$100	\$2,884	\$129,780
GAL Fees	51	\$1,500	\$5,989	\$305,450
Asset Loss ¹	43	\$6,500	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$29,750	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$6,500) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME - MONTHS

Median months lost		24	2 yrs
Mean months lost		31	2.6 yrs
Total across all families		1,531	127.6 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · OHIO

Most families documenting in Ohio are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		42	42%
Not provided		32	32%
Case closed: within last 2 years		14	14%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		11	11%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		44	44%
Family Court Only		31	31%
Unknown		22	22%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		2	2%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		22	22%
3 – 5 years		18	18%
Over 10 years		11	11%
5+ years		9	9%
5 – 10 years		8	8%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		33	33%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		28	28%
50/50 Joint		13	13%
Full Custody		10	10%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		7	7%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Hancock		5	5%
Hamilton		4	4%
Montgomery		4	4%
Cuyahoga		3	3%
Guernsey		3	3%
Williams		3	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		26	26%
Other: (Short answer)		13	13%
Family Court		12	12%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		10	10%
High Conflict Divorce		8	8%

05 PARENT VOICES — OHIO

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Terminated my Parental Rights in Fraud and destroyed my children.

— PATSY

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Kids taken without hearing. Zero evidence of abuse or neglect. When I responded and called them all out on Facebook I was punished with jail time and more lost time with my children. My ex and my ex boss got together and turned my posts into my coal mining job for 12 years I was [...]

— OHIO PARENT · NICK

MORE VOICES FROM OHIO

False claims to CPS by my boyfriend's ex girlfriend. Kids were on a safety plan for 2 weeks while I got drug tested and came back negative

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took my grandson away and gave him to the abusers who then kept him and his siblings from coming home to me

— ROBIN

Because I'm deaf - system use my abuser and his mother as their primary and believe them because they have voice and I don't. They lie a lot about me. Judge refused to see my proof motion. They never on my side. I even show them my proof of abuser hit me and raped me. The judge [...]

— AVRIL

They took away my rights as a mother to raise my children as I see fit. I was always either a stay at home mom or I worked as needed and was forced to work full-time. They took my kids away during the school time, but not during the summer, because I didn't believe in the very [...]

— KAYLEIGH

The depression and hurt of not being able to a mother to your children is devastating. My children suffered abuse and mental health abuse.

— BELINDA

This system has ripped my kids from wverything they knew. They have caused hurt anger and my kids are suffering and lashing out.

— MERSADEES

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Shattered the relationship with son, destroyed my son's image of me, his self esteem, his identity, placed him in the home with the abuser.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Illegal alien with a conviction of sexual abuse of a child was given full custody of a minor child. Parental (entire maternal family) alienation has been endorsed by family court.

— ROBYN

I have been grieving my kids that are STILL ALIVE because of the Clark county ohio family court!! LOST MEMORIES, LOST TIMES, AND A BONDS STOLEN . just like that....gone I LOVE YOU JULIUS AND BRYLON

— BRIANNA

An assistant prosecuting attorney acting as a civil custody lawyer al fight and suppressed a 25 year violent criminal history for his private client. Attorneys judges, GALCPS and even neighboring counties are working together, not in the best interest of the child, but in the [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I cry every day, it was always me and my son, every day since he was born, I look at the pictures of me and him together my son clinging onto me when he was little and I break down and cry, we used to order pizza and have pizza and movie night once a month, I taught my son how [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Turned me into a civil rights activist.

— CAREY ANN

Removed my kids to ex parte without letting my attorney know.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took away our entire lives. Completely destroyed our mental health. Made my children believe I'm the bad guy and don't love them or care about them. Told them I wasn't their mother and their father wasn't their father.

— ALEXANDREA

Allowed this person to commit criminal crimes against me by not allowing me to see my children and has gotten away with every single one.

— SARA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This system has caused a ginormous splinter in the bond I hold with my children. Refused and erased my ancestral traditions and our way of life.

— RAVEN

took my daughter who was sexually abused, and put her back with her abuser in the same home the abuse occurred. she then got molested again in under a month of contact

— HEIDI

It has caused severe trauma for both of us. My daughter is not getting the medical care she needs, and I worry about her safety everyday. My daughter already had anxiety prior to separation. they destroyed our bond and all the good things ive done her whole life.

— HEATHER

The system has single-handedly divided and destroyed my sense of security, my sense of peace, my children from my life and allowed the abuser to publicly look like a hero, forcing the mother to pay a child support for two kids while residing in Ohio and kids being in California [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Created litigation abuse, DARVO, violates the constitution land of law, me allowing to speak, violation of due process.

— JESSICA

The system falsely accused my fiancé, and then even after her charge have been dismissed. I am now still being punished years later.

— RACHEL

They destroyed our confidence and consistency. They destroyed my child's mental health and mine. They did nothing but lie to help make that happen.

— ANNA

Butler and warren county ohio destroyed my family and took time I will never get back

— JESSICA

It has caused further trauma, cause children to cry out for help and be denied so they turn to committing crimes as thats what they are being taught instead of protected. It tears apart siblings and grandparents and great grandparents.

— CATHERINE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Despite having a protection order and evidence of abuse and coercive control and opposing party not following any court orders (psych evaluation and hair strand test) and having multiple contempt of court, the GAL is suggesting joint custody.

— EMILY

Complete and total destruction of our happy, loving family with use of psychological warfare to all 3 of my children and myself!

— RENE

The courts didn't just take my rights — they took my child, my time, my voice, my safety, and the chance to protect the one person who depended on me to survive.

— TACI

I moved to a different state after my kids were taken. I went from a successful career driven single mother to an unemployed, homeless woman in full blown active addiction where I am currently.

— AMBER

Has taken everything i had purpose to live for

— AMANDA

Destoryed everthing i built and handed it to the person who abandon us for years.

— MEGAN

My child was taken at birth without any allegations of abuse or neglect, based solely on a past case, and I have been left without clear reunification steps while being limited to minimal visitation.”

— JUSTIN

“Truth doesn't panic when it's questioned. Stay patient— what's real has a way of rising to the surface.”

— MOLLY

Cps has done so much pain for my family that I cant get back 2 years

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Took my kids out of a loving home to place them where ever they could following all the recommendations they set to have unsupervised visits so we can move on to overnight and then home but I never one time got more parenting time or any of the unsupervised visits or overnight. [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has completely broke us and failed us. Out of all the people that I know in our county it has lost their children to the system. I am the only one that was able to get mine back..

— MATTALYNN

“This system drained our family emotionally and financially, forcing us to spend everything we had just to be heard, while separating us from our children without timely answers or accountability. It turned protection into punishment and survival into a constant fight.”

— BRITNEY

Took phone calls away my visits ect please call I have so much to say

— TRISHA

The court process has turned what should have been a child-focused custody matter into years of instability, forced separation, and emotional strain on my children and me. The lack of accountability has caused lasting harm to our family relationships

— ANNA

My family has turned their back on each other has broken sibling bonds and made some of my kids rebel agaist the system and caused ttust issues against the system

— ANDREA

Violated my rights kidnapped my child and used her estate as leverage of extortion in commerce against me using a fictitious scarecrow and tricking me into their jurisdiction to be used in commerce as a current day slave.

— HARLEY

Has made my life harder financially, mentally and it's made me lose hope that the system is good and fair and needed

— ROBERT

Completely ruined my life and changed the outcome of my daughters life.

— JENNIFER

57 Ohio parents submitted ranked quotes. 44 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/oh.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Ohio report comes from Ohio respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Ohio — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 100 Ohio families reporting here are not the universe of Ohio families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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